

Team formation in start-up studios

A qualitative research

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Purpose - The purpose of this paper is to explore the **start-up studio model** and how start-up studios **compose teams** for their start-ups.

Methodology - For this qualitative study, **seven European start-up studios** were interviewed using a **semi-structured interview** format. These interviews were transcribed and thematically analyzed using the **six-step approach for thematic analysis** of Braun and Clarke ([Clarke & Braun, 2013](#)).

Findings - This research showed that the **team formation process starts with the recruitment of a CEO, CTO or both**. Their **networks serve as a foundation for further recruitment**. Start-up studios prioritize **three key properties: prior entrepreneurial experience, prior industry-alike experience and an entrepreneurial mindset**. Finding profiles that fit these requirements happens through **spontaneous applications, the start-up and start-up studio founder's networks and through external engagement** such as entrepreneurial events. Start-up studios **use the attractiveness of their projects** and brand, **equity** in the new start-up **and other long-term incentives** often based on key performance indicators **to attract the needed profiles**. **Teamwork is fostered by focusing on a team member's fit and acquiring core management members that possess solid leadership soft skills**. They also use trial periods to evaluate how well new members fit within the team. Finally, **some start-ups rely on a fixed team** as the start-up team for each project.

Limitations - Seven interviews were conducted with seven different start-up studios. This **limited sample might not represent the diverse population of start-up studios**.

Originality/value - This study contributes to understanding the team formation processes in European startup studios, offering insights into team formation processes used in a business model that is gaining in popularity.

Keywords - Start-up studios, team formation, entrepreneurial ecosystems, venture builders, incubators, recruitment strategies.

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¹This document might contain (parts of) texts from earlier submitted documents within the same educational programme, related tot the Master's Thesis process of the same author as the author of this work.

Introduction

As digitization increases, economies in Europe have to rely on start-ups to innovate in a way to keep up with new technological trends (Jesemann, 2020). Globally, nine out of ten start-ups fail (Switters, 2017). In order to support innovative start-ups, incubators can be used to support these new businesses through the difficult process of innovation (Markley & McNamara, 1995). Since the late 1990s, a new form of incubators has emerged in the entrepreneurial landscape, the start-up studio. A start-up studio named 'Idealab' was one of the first in 1996. However, earlier businesses employing a similar model emerged more than 20 years ago. In recent years, this type of incubator has gained popularity, showing an increase from less than 100 in 2015 (Chernova, 2015) to more than 800 start-up studios today (Pog, 2023). The name 'start-up studio' is the most used for the business model, but as it gained popularity, it was also referred to with other names. The most frequent ones are venture builder, start-up factory, company builder, venture studio and start-up foundry (Lawrence, Fulton, Narowski, & Hurwitz, 2019).

Differentiating itself from conventional incubators and accelerators, start-up studios take a unique approach by internally conceiving, launching and nurturing multiple start-ups simultaneously. It's a venture that creates new ventures. By pooling their resources, such as financial capital, expertise and management, they try to give start-ups a higher chance of survival. Typical for a start-up studio is that the studio has to recruit a new team for each start-up created. For this process, studios employ methods to find the right members and have different visions on the process of team formation.

This research aims to explore the start-up studio model and the team formation for start-ups created by this new type of incubator. The thesis starts with delving into literature about the business incubator and the start-up studio. This is followed by describing literature on team formation in the entrepreneurial world. After the literature review, the methods used to collect and analyze interview data are presented. Afterwards, there is a section about the findings collected from the interviews with start-up studios. Finally, the conclusion follows, highlighting the important parts of this research.

Chapter 1

Literature review

In the preliminary literature review, we briefly present prior research articles relevant to our topic. Section 1.1 and 1.2 give a description and definition of incubators and the start-up studio model, while the remaining sections provide a basis for our research on the team formation process.

1.1 The traditional incubator model

To gain a better understanding of the start-up studio, it is essential to provide a precise definition and description of the business incubator. In essence, a business incubator is an organization that aids young companies and entrepreneurs in their growth by offering various supportive services. The concept of the business model was first implemented in 1959 by the Batavia Industrial Center and since the 1980s, the incubator business concept has gained popularity worldwide (Kilcrease, 2012).

The International Business Innovation Association, or InBIA, is the largest association of business organizations, with the largest membership and business support network in the world. Its main goal is to support incubators, accelerators, coworking spaces and other entrepreneurial support organizations. More than half of the world's incubators are connected to the InBIA. The InBIA identified three key characteristics that distinguish a business incubator: first, the mission to provide business assistance; second, the presence of staff who deliver and coordinate business assistance to clients; and lastly, the design aimed at leading its companies to self-sufficiency. These three characteristics remain relevant in the current context (Kilcrease, 2012).

Every service of an incubator can be categorized into five main categories. The first and oldest one is infrastructure. The Batavia, the first incubator established in 1959, initially focused mainly on providing office space to multiple businesses (Kilcrease, 2012). Infrastructure includes essential resources such as computers, security and recreational equipment, effectively positioning incubators to compete with science and technology parks. Secondly, an incubator can provide office services, including a reception desk and secretarial and accounting support. Furthermore, financial services, particularly venture funding, are another critical offering (Ram, 2023).

A fourth significant service involves start-up assistance. Incubators often play an advisory role, assisting start-ups in planning their next steps, navigating administrative, legal, accounting and taxation challenges and aiding in the development of convincing business plans (Ram, 2023).

Lastly, incubators serve as networking hubs, offering entrepreneurs access to a broad network of connections that would otherwise take years to compose independently. Incubators can facilitate introductions to key individuals, such as potential customers, skilled employees to fill gaps in expertise, or venture capitalists interested in investment opportunities ([Ram, 2023](#)).

1.1.1 Types of incubators

As the number of business incubators worldwide continues to rise, their differentiation from one another increases too, adapting to the evolving environment and increasing competition. Consequently, this diversification requires a way of categorization. Below, three categorizations for incubators are given.

A first approach to categorize incubators is by sector or industry. Traditionally, incubators were open to all industries, but there's a growing trend towards sector-specific incubators. One common type is the kitchen incubator, focusing specifically on the food industry. In this industry, having an own working space can be expensive. This means incubators can be a helpful resource for these companies by renting out low-cost kitchens ([Roshni, 2022](#)). Another prominent sector for incubators is the medical industry. These incubators aim to foster innovation and entrepreneurship in medical technologies, providing support to innovators, start-ups and established companies through technology and business incubation services. Finally, the social incubator can also be seen as a company-specific type incubator, although these don't serve one specific industry. They aim to serve the public good as their goal is to provide social entrepreneurs with resources and help them innovate ([Roshni, 2022](#)).

A second way to categorize incubators is by the kind of programs that they offer and what services they are specialized in. An example is the virtual business incubator, which only offers online services ([Roshni, 2022](#)). A more popular and more recent example is the business accelerator. In most literature about the accelerator, the concept is compared to the traditional business incubator, meaning that the accelerator is often seen as more than just an incubator. Both aim to support start-ups, but accelerators differentiate themselves by working more intensively over a shorter fixed period, often about 6 months, with the specific goal of accelerating growth. They usually provide these services in exchange for a portion of the equity. Furthermore, an accelerator works mostly with cohorts or 'classes' of start-ups rather than individual firms. Additionally, there are alternatives to the accelerator. As the traditional accelerator usually only accepts businesses who already have a minimum viable product, the seed accelerator focuses on beginning start-ups while the corporate accelerators focus on more mature companies. To get into an accelerator program, the firms need to go through a highly competitive application program ([Miller & Bound, 2011](#)).

Lastly, incubators can also be categorized by the phase of the companies that they support. As mentioned before, there are companies that focus on helping out more mature firms. The start-up studio differentiates itself in this way. This type of incubator develops and launches multiple start-ups by providing shared resources, expertise and support to entrepreneurs with the goal of increasing the likelihood of success for each

new venture ([Roshni, 2022](#)). This kind of incubator will be explained in depth in the following section and will be the subject of this thesis.

1.2 The start-up studio model

In what follows, a closer look is taken at the start-up studio model. First, the paper will delve into the history of this new incubator model. Then it will explain the model itself and present a definition. Next, the different types of start-up studios and the operational model are reviewed. Finally, the differences with and advantages over traditional incubator models are debated.

1.2.1 History

Idealab is known as the first start-up studio in history, founded in 1996 by Bill Gross, an entrepreneur who already had multiple success stories to his name. In the first start-up studio, many different business ideas were tested in parallel, hoping some had the potential to turn into a viable business. This strategy delivered more than 150 companies with 45 IPOs, or initial public offerings, and acquisitions up to today ([Idealab, 2024](#)). By employing such a model, Idealab introduced a new perspective on entrepreneurship; not waiting for one potentially great idea, but actively testing a whole range of business ideas at the same time. This is also referred to as parallel entrepreneurship. It took some time for this idea to gain popularity. However, almost thirty years later the start-up studio concept has never been more popular, with over eight hundred start-up studios today ([Lawrence et al., 2019](#)) ([StartupStudioInsider, 2022](#)).

There are several 'waves' of increasing numbers of start-up studios, which are frequently mentioned while discussing the development and history of venture builders ([Lawrence et al., 2019](#)). The first wave dates back to 2007. Idealab wasn't the only start-up studio anymore thanks to the founding of venture builders such as Betaworks and Obvious Corp. The latter booked an early success with the foundation of Twitter, now X. Betaworks is a start-up studio and a seed-stage venture capitalist and is mainly known for investments in Twitter, Airbnb, GIPHY and Bitly. With the successes of these venture builders, the next waves followed each other at a faster pace. Most of these first venture builders focused on developing and launching internet-based start-ups. In the following years, many startups remained mostly in this sector, although parallel entrepreneurship also extended to other markets ([Lawrence et al., 2019](#)) ([StartupStudioInsider, 2022](#)).

The next wave of venture builders occurred around 2013, leading to approximately eighty start-up studios worldwide at the end of that year. An increasing number of previously successful entrepreneurs were venturing into parallel entrepreneurship, indicating the growing appeal of the start-up studio concept. An example is Expa, founded by Uber co-founder Garret Camp with the help of Foursquare co-founder Naveen Selvadurai ([Lapowsky, 2014](#)). Another famous start-up studio from this wave is Science Inc., known for the foundation of the Dollar Shave Club and Bird ([Lawrence et al., 2019](#)) ([StartupStudioInsider, 2022](#)).

The third wave occurred in 2018. Start-ups created by these studios often had a focus on artificial intelligence while also trying to reshape the entrepreneurial economy and differentiate themselves from other start-up studios. Differentiation is a logical consequence of the constant increase in number of start-up studios worldwide, which in 2018 already totaled more than two hundred studios. The studios could differentiate themselves not only on the industry where they were active, but also on how they did business. This thesis will take a closer look at this in Section 1.2.5. (Lawrence et al., 2019) (StartupStudioInsider, 2022).

During the writing of this thesis, the startup studio is still gaining popularity, surpassing eight hundred start-up studios worldwide. It's challenging to provide an exact number of start-up studios worldwide, since the start-up ecosystem is constantly evolving and new studios emerge regularly. Additionally, some start-up studios may not be publicly listed or easily identifiable (Lawrence et al., 2019) (StartupStudioInsider, 2022).

1.2.2 Definition

A start-up studio, or venture builder, is a company that creates new companies. As some businesses produce clothes, food or other products, the start-up studio produces start-ups. They aim to produce quality companies with fewer resources. Although this definition is simple, it captures the core principle of this type of company or type of entrepreneurship (Lawrence et al., 2019).

For a part, these start-up studios are holding companies that own equity in the various start-ups it created. After the creation, they hope to get as much return as possible on their investments in their businesses by an IPO or acquisition. Good venture builders, however, are much more operationally involved than holdings in portfolio businesses. They raise all kinds of resources and capital, work with suitable teams for each venture, run marketing campaigns, deliver valuable network contacts and could eventually manage a company through the first entrepreneurial phases of a venture (Diallo, 2015).

As previously stated, start-up studios produce start-ups. They do not develop one project at a time, but develop multiple projects at once and try to build a business out of the most promising ideas. Ideas can be generated internally, but there are some start-up studios that accept ideas coming from external entrepreneurs, who typically then become part of the entrepreneurial team (Lapowsky, 2014).

The main difference with traditional incubators or accelerators is that a venture builder is involved in the start-up from the very beginning, including idea identification and validation. This involvement varies depending on whether they actively seek ideas themselves or rely on external entrepreneurs who have business ideas with promising potential. Unlike incubators and accelerators, venture builders do not run competitive programs for existing start-ups. Instead, they source business ideas from their network or external entrepreneurs and allocate internal teams to develop them (McDermott, 2020). As mentioned earlier in Section 1.1.1, the second big difference between a start-up studio and an accelerator is the duration of the period over which the start-up

receives support. An accelerator mentors the firms intensively for a short fixed period, usually between three and six months, while start-up studios are not time-limited (Miller & Bound, 2011).

The borderline between a start-up studio and other types of incubators can sometimes be vague. However, we can, according to Thibaud Elziere who is a co-founder of Hexa, distinguish 3 elements that define a start-up studio. The first element is internal ideation, meaning that the incubator has to be involved in the idea identification and the studio is a co-founder of the start-up. Here lies the differentiation with early-stage investors. The second element is repetition. The goal of the company is to build companies consistently and sequentially, not waiting for one unicorn idea and only focusing on that one business. The last element is that a venture builder has a clearly defined infrastructure. The studio is not an empty structure with a portfolio of companies, but has a strong team, networks and other resources that can help the start-ups in their first years of getting to and surviving in the market (Elziere, 2014).

1.2.3 Advantages

Start-up failure rate is known to be high, at approximately ninety percent. (Howarth, 2022). The reasons for failure are broad. Bill Gross and GSSN, now Morrow, identified the reasons for these failures and categorized them into five groups: team (32 percent), idea (28 percent), funding (14 percent), business (24 percent) and timing (42 percent) (Lawrence et al., 2019). The start-up studio can provide assistance to start-ups in almost each mentioned category. Similar to any other type of incubator, start-ups can benefit from the experience, knowledge, funding and network contacts from the incubators. However, a start-up studio maximizes those benefits by delivering their advice and involvement from the beginning. Normally, the venture builder has experience in entrepreneurship and can also select the right people for the right job in order to create the perfect team for each project. With this approach, the chances of everything being done correctly from the very start increase.

Diversification is an additional significant advantage that a start-up studio possesses over single start-ups or venture capitalists. The high failure rate of single start-ups and traditional entrepreneurship indicates that these ventures are risky projects. By working on multiple start-ups, the team can diversify the risk across the multiple start-ups. Not all start-ups have to turn into businesses. One successful project can compensate for many failures. Secondly, a start-up studio is involved as early as possible in the project. A younger start-up contains more risk compared to a mature firm. As an example, investing in a public company now or a *cash cow*, such as Apple, carries little risk. Consequently, the expected return is fairly low. On the other hand, investing in an early start-up includes high potential returns. Additionally, obtaining a larger ownership stake in a business at an early stage is easier. These two advantages show how the returns of the model make the start-up studio concept more popular, but not what the impact of performance is. In addition to the previously discussed benefits of being active from the beginning, shared resources also provide start-ups with significant advantages. The studio can share resources over the different projects, such as data, recruiting, sales, expertise, offices and of course, the in-house staff (Fishbein, 2014).

Those advantages translate into numbers, collected by Dutch start-up studio Duodeka. The internal rate of return of a start-up created by a start-up studio is 53 percent, significantly higher than the 21,3 percent of a traditional start-up. The time from zero, the beginning of the start-up, to series A, the first funding round, is only 25 months for a start-up from a studio, compared to the 56 months of a traditional start-up. From zero to seed, a start-up from a studio only needs 11 months, while a traditional start-up needs on average 36 months (Duodeka, 2023). Similar results are visible when looking at percentages to reach a certain round, instead of the time it takes to reach a funding round, as in this instance gathered by GSSN (Zasowski, 2020). Most start-ups, 84 percent, from a venture builder raise successfully a seed round. 72 percent progresses to the A round. For traditional start-ups, this percentage is only 42 percent. As a result, 60 percent of all start-ups created by a studio reach the A round. Overall, we see that start-ups from venture builders have a 30 percent higher success rate compared to single start-ups (Zasowski, 2020).

1.2.4 Operational model

The early involvement of the start-up studio stands out, providing us with an operational framework distinct from other incubators. The most straightforward approach to understanding how venture builders operate is to observe their progression through various stages. These steps are generally consistent across different ideas that they try to develop into businesses. Naturally, if it becomes evident at a certain stage that an idea lacks sufficient potential, attention can shift to a new concept (Lawrence et al., 2019). These stages are typically uniform across most start-up studios and recognizing them can be helpful in categorizing studios into different groups later on.

There are different perspectives on these stages, but they all essentially deliver the same message and run from zero to exit. The first step is identifying the problem, which may be found through a market analysis. The following step involves finding a solution that can be developed into a business. While not all businesses originate from a problem, they typically all start with an idea or an opportunity. To fit all start-ups, the first stage is idea identification. Followed by idea validation, the studio tests the idea and determines whether it has any chance of becoming a successful business in the future through market and competition analysis, feasibility assessment and scalability validation. Once a viable business idea is chosen, the next step is forming a team of co-founders to bring the idea to life. The venture builder usually acquires twenty to forty percent of the equity in the newly formed company. Co-founders may include entrepreneurs, market experts, or individuals with the necessary skills to execute the opportunity. This thesis will zoom in on this particular aspect, the team formation. Subsequently, resources such as funding, office space, mentorship and other supportive services are provided from within the studio to help the start-ups progress. With the core team in place and resources allocated, the start-up prepares to enter the market by creating a minimum viable product or initial prototype. This will be tested and refined as much as needed until the team deems the product or service as ready to be launch to the market. The studio continues to support the start-ups post-launch, offering assistance in marketing, strategy, funding opportunities and operational guidance.

The goal is to scale the start-up, pursue growth and eventually prepare it for an exit through acquisition or IPO ([Lawrence et al., 2019](#)) ([Bergen, 2023](#)).

To summarize, six phases can be identified for every start-up that a studio attempts to develop. At any moment in the process, the start-up can be dissolved if the business idea does not work as planned. Starting with idea identification (1), followed by idea validation (2). If the right team has been found (3), the studio can allocate the needed resources to the start-up (4), in return for equity. Then the start-up begins with product development (5), in order to launch it. After the launch, the goal is to scale up and eventually make an exit through IPO or acquisition (6) ([Lawrence et al., 2019](#)) ([Bergen, 2023](#)).

1.2.5 Categorization

To conclude this exploratory part of the research, it can be helpful to look at different classification schemes before delving into team formation. The first popular classification is between operator-led, company-led and investor-led start-up studios. Operator-driven studios are led by experienced entrepreneurs who play an active role in the development and guidance of start-ups, utilizing their broad knowledge and expertise. Meanwhile, investor-driven studios are piloted by investors or venture capitalists who offer financial support, strategic guidance and networking opportunities to promising start-ups. Agency-driven studios, on the other hand, use the technical and creative skills of digital or design agencies to conceptualize, develop and promote innovative goods and services ([Saba, 2014](#)).

The source of the business idea is another common method to divide venture builders into two groups. The first group creates their ideas internally, meaning the studio is completely involved from zero to exit. These venture builders spend time researching and analysing markets in order to seek business opportunities. Their advantage is that the idea fully originates from the studio, which gives them more control on the team formation. The other group, including big studios such as Betaworks and Expa, attracts ideas externally from other driven entrepreneurs. These entrepreneurs are looking for a validation of their idea and needed resources, while the studio looks for a good idea. If the entrepreneur and the studio fit, a start-up can be set up. Normally, the entrepreneur who generated the idea becomes a co-founder and a core member of the team ([Insead, 2018](#)).

A last categorization depends on the source of the talent, ideas and funding. Nine types of start-up studios exist in this category. The first type is the traditional model, the studio that builds new companies from the ground up. This is often referred to as the venture builder. The second type is the agency builder. They raise funds and resources through an external and fully functional digital agency, in order to spin off their portfolio start-ups in exchange for equity. This type of studio can often be found in the advertising, software or media sectors. The third type are venture capital labs, which are attached to bigger venture capital firms and pays for fees and investments in the portfolio companies. Next, there are the accelerator studios, such as 500labs. They're a combination of a start-up studio and an accelerator. They tend to have rolling start

dates, long engagements and greater funding compared to traditional start-up studios. The fifth type is called the corporate studio. These studios are formally or informally supporting the innovation of a larger corporation. This corporation can provide powerful assets to the studio, such as IP (intellectual property), distribution channels, know-how and the corporation could be an early customer. Often, the corporate studio has to work within the parameters of the corporation (Lawrence et al., 2019). Additionally, there are university and government studios. They commercialize the findings or IP of the universities or government and work closely with scholars to build viable businesses. The seventh type is the racer studio or the clone factory. This kind of studio identifies start-ups with high potential and copies their concept in other regions. These studios are lean because they don't require as much innovative research. Finally, two other types could still be identified. First are the hybrid studios. These are a mix of the previous models and are often unique in their way of working. Lastly, the ninth type, is a studio that lacks structure or a main model. This can be seen as a group of entrepreneurs that works together in order to make some successful start-ups. They work in a more informal setting, but do create new companies repetitively (Lawrence et al., 2019).

1.3 Social networks

1.3.1 Network models

Since team formation often requires the recruitment of team members, the social networks of the founders can have a considerable impact. Every start-up has a set of crucial resources needed to start. The quality of the networks of the founders thus impacts if and how easily they can find the required people.

A paper by Howard E. Aldrich and Phillip H. Kim highlights three important models for social networks: random networks, small-world networks and scale-free networks (Aldrich & Kim, 2007). These models offer three different perspectives on social networks. The first one, random networks, assumes a highly individualized world where everyone in the network has the ability to access everyone else and will do so randomly. The second model, the small world model, assumes a highly clustered world where the ability for someone to form ties strongly relies on that person's environment. Finally, the scale-free network model assumes few 'hubs' of people with weak connections. (Aldrich & Kim, 2007).

The small-world and scale-free model might both, to some extent, be applicable to the situation where founders of start-up studios find themselves during team formation. The close environment of the founders should have a big impact on which people they'll be able to connect with. Founders are somewhat limited to the people available in their proximity. Support for this assumption is given in Section 1.3.2. On the other hand, founders can have ties with people who have many connections to potential team members, which is more similar to a scale-free model for social networks.

1.3.2 Impact of networks

In Section 1.3.1, we discussed the different models for social networks. We assumed that the close environment, or strong-tie network, of founders could play a pivotal role in their ventures. Prior research supports this assumption. It has been shown that **entrepreneurs who can rely on their strong-tie network**, which includes close friends and family, **can increase the success of the entrepreneur's start-ups**. Weak-tie networks however, haven't been proven to have a significant impact on the success of future ventures (Brüderl & Preisendörfer, 1998).

1.4 Team member selection

A paper by Lazar defines **two main strategies for member selection: a resource-seeking one and one prioritizing interpersonal attraction**. These two strategies have a different focus during the selection of team members (Lazar et al., 2019).

In a **resource-seeking team formation strategy**, founders will focus on the need for **resources**. They'll rely solely on their **expertise and experience**. This has the advantage that the overall knowledge base of the team will be larger, as members can rely on each other's knowledge. A **drawback** of this approach is that these **teams are heterogeneous**. This leads to a lack of shared understanding, which **impedes coordination and communication** within the team (Lazar et al., 2019).

A **second strategy is interpersonal attraction**. Unlike a resource-seeking strategy, founders **prioritize their similarities with team members** over their expertise and experience. These **teams are homogeneous, thus increasing coordination** and communication within the team. The **drawback** of this strategy is the **lack of a diverse skill and knowledge** set within the team, resulting in a restriction on accessible knowledge (Lazar et al., 2019).

Often, founders will **employ both of these strategies**. They will either combine the two simultaneously, which is called a **hybrid strategy**, or use them sequentially, which is called a **shifting strategy** (Lazar et al., 2019). The **shifting strategy** usually happens from an interpersonal attraction strategy to a resource-seeking strategy, which allows founders to address deficiencies found in the team (Lazar et al., 2019).

1.5 Entrepreneurial team formation

In eighty-five percent of cases, an entrepreneur doesn't start their venture alone. Since they often won't possess all skills and knowledge required to materialize their idea, they resort to additional team members. Since these team members that possess the necessary skills and knowledge are crucial for the success of the venture, it is vital to understand how these entrepreneurial teams are formed (Lazar et al., 2019).

A paper on team formation highlights four crucial aspects of team formation: candidate pools, information sources, selection criteria and cooperation patterns (Klada, 2018).

Founders of new ventures often have trouble with brand legitimacy. Due to the nature of these companies, the founders might not have had a successful track record yet. This makes attracting new members difficult and thus gives for small candidate pools. To overcome this obstacle, founders will tend to resort to their own strong-tie networks (Leung, Zhang, Wong, & Foo, 2006). Another study showed that some small start-ups use their networks and organised events to increase their publicity and promote candidate attraction (Klada, 2018).

Another problem founders often have to overcome is the lack of experience in recruitment. As finding and acquiring new team members is a skill of its own, founders might not possess this ability. Hence, as stated before, they'll resort to their strong-tie networks and recommendations of peers in this network (Klada, 2018).

As for selection criteria, founders typically share the same set of desired attributes in new members, but prioritize them in a different order. Overall, they deem soft skills as more important than hard skills, which creates strong and resilient teams. This can be explained because of the way that finding high-quality profiles that possess all necessary hard-skills is a resource-intensive tasks, one which many new start-ups might not be able to accomplish (Klada, 2018).

Finally, the study by Klada found that founders make use of three instruments to acquire new members under the financial constraints that start-ups are typically in: offering decision-making power, offering future prospects inside of the company, reducing labor costs by offering half-time employment and eliminating labor costs altogether by presenting the job function to fresh graduates as a way to gain experience in the field (Klada, 2018).

1.6 Entrepreneurial failure

Background experience for chosen members of a new venture can have a significant impact on the team's performance. To get a better idea of the impact of prior entrepreneurial experience, or more specifically failed entrepreneurial experience, a closer look is taken at a research paper by Lattacher and Wdowiak (2020). The paper applies Kolb's experiential learning model (Kolb, 1984) to an entrepreneurial context. Kolb's model uses four stages to describe experiential learning: concrete experience, reflective observation, abstract conceptualization and active experimentation.

The first stage, concrete experience, encompasses the venture failure and the entrepreneur's immediate reaction to it. Research on this phase has shown that the most impactful factor for the reaction of the entrepreneur is their perception of the failure. The failure itself doesn't have much influence on the degree of entrepreneurial learning but rather the subjective perception and attitude taken by the entrepreneur (Lattacher & Wdowiak, 2020).

The second stage, reflective observation, focuses on how the failure is interpreted by the entrepreneur. In this stage, the emotional mindset is the most important factor. How an entrepreneur recovers from grief will impact how he draws conclusions from his failed experience. The amount of emotional resilience is believed to impact the emotions of the entrepreneur at this stage (Lattacher & Wdowiak, 2020).

Abstract conceptualization is the third stage. This stage describes how insights from the failed experience are converted into abstract learning outcomes. In cases of overconfidence within the entrepreneur, this abstract learning might be limited, which may lead to an incorrect perception of their learning after the experience. This might then lead to additional subsequent failures. As the abstract conceptualization of the experience is a process heavily reliant on the creative ability of the entrepreneur, possessing abstract thinking abilities and creativity may play a pivotal role in a correct learning from the failure (Lattacher & Wdowiak, 2020).

Finally, the last stage, active experimentation describes the application of the learned insights from the previous paragraph to outcomes in practice. Having gained crucial insights on the causes of the previous failure, entrepreneurs might adapt their behavior when thinking about negotiations with venture capitalists, increased tendency towards internationalization and adopting a more proactive strategy (Lattacher & Wdowiak, 2020).

Having had failed experiences as an entrepreneur can thus have a positive impact on the success of subsequent ventures, but how the entrepreneur perceives their learning from the failure plays a pivotal role. If the entrepreneur has a strong degree of emotional resilience, can draw correct conclusions about their failed venture and possesses the necessary creative skills to convert these insights into abstract learning from the experience, then their success in subsequent ventures can increase.

1.7 Entrepreneurial mindset

In the previous section, an examination was done on the possible effects of the network, skills and entrepreneurial failure on the success of the entrepreneur. In this section, a final possible impactful factor is discussed: the entrepreneurial mindset.

Research has shown that **long-term entrepreneurial success requires a certain entrepreneurial state of mind**. A study from 2020 (Duckworth, Peterson, Matthews, & Kelly, 2007) explored the impact of *grit* on entrepreneurial success. *Grit* can be defined as **"the perseverance and passion for long-term goals"** (Duckworth, Peterson, Matthews, & Kelly, 2007, p. 1087). *Grit* has **two dimensions: perseverance of effort and consistency of interest** (Duckworth et al., 2007). The 2020 study examined four sets of hypotheses: the relationship between the two dimensions of *grit* and career success outcomes, the relationship between the two dimensions of *grit* and resilience, the relationship between resilience and three facets of career success and finally, the mediating role of resilience in the relationship between *grit* and career success (Salisu, Hashim, Mashi, & Aliyu, 2020).

The first set of hypothesis tests, which examined the relationship between the two dimensions of *grit* and career success, showed that the **perseverance of effort** dimension of *grit* was **positively related to entrepreneurial career success**. Secondly, it was found that **resilience is positively related to both dimensions of *grit***. Although both dimensions had a positive relation, the perseverance of effort has a slightly stronger relation with *grit* than the consistency of effort. The third set of tested hypotheses found that **entrepreneurial resilience was positively related to career success**. In other words, to be successful in entrepreneurship, an entrepreneur has to be able to overcome let-downs and stay motivated through difficult situations. Finally, the study found that this **link between *grit* and career success is mediated by resilience** (Salisu et al., 2020).

Chapter 2

Methodology

As the aim of our study is to gain a better understanding of the processes used by start-up studios for their team formations, it employs a **qualitative approach**. A **thematic analysis** is used to identify recurring themes and patterns in the data, which allows for the building of a theoretical framework on how team formation processes in start-up studios occur. An elaboration on the participants, data collection, data analysis and limitations is done in the following sections.

2.1 Participants

Participants for this study were members of start-up studios. Their **positions range from founders to employees responsible for the recruitment** and composition of new members in each start-up. To receive a broad set of information, **both larger and successful as well as smaller and younger start-up studios were interviewed**. Out of the seven studios interviewed, three were five years old or younger, two were between six and eight years old and two had been active for over eight years.

To determine which companies qualify as start-up studios, the companies were evaluated to fit with the definition of a start-up studio stated in a previous Section [1.2.2](#).

In total, members from seven different start-up studios were interviewed. Despite the limited amount of interviews conducted, the sample includes start-up studios in a wide range of industries. **All of the start-up studios were active in Europe**.

2.2 Data collection

The seven interviews were conducted using a semi-structured interview format. This study used **three categories of questions: the team formation process, team member characteristics and the founders' networks**. By asking open-ended questions and probing further, aforementioned themes could be explored while revealing additional relevant information.

Due to geographical constraints, all seven interviews were done using videoconferencing. The audios of the interviews were recorded to be transcribed later. Interviewees were informed about the confidentiality of the information that we collected. Five of the seven interviews were conducted in English, while two were conducted in Dutch.

2.3 Data analysis

The transcriptions of the interviews were used as the basis for the six-step approach for thematic analysis of Braun and Clarke (Clarke & Braun, 2013). These six steps include: familiarization with the data, coding, searching for themes, reviewing themes, defining and naming themes and finally, the writing.

During the familiarization phase, the transcriptions were thoroughly read while at the same time adding some first notes and highlighting important parts of text. In the coding phase, all transcriptions were read again, while adding *codes*, which can be understood as labels that correspond to topics and themes that were relevant to the three themes mentioned in Section 2.2. These codes were then grouped into themes, with each theme containing codes that are closely related. Next, themes were reviewed. During this phase, coding was split into separate codes or similar codes were merged together. Additionally, this phase aimed to ensure that all codes were categorized into the most fitting theme. Then, themes were given a name that best described all the coding that they contained. Finally, these themes were used to write our findings. For each theme, the different codes are elaborated on using their linked text from the transcriptions.

This approach allows the research to identify all relevant recurring themes in the data and to cover every important aspect on the subject of team formation.

2.4 Limitations

As the population of start-up studios is still in a growth phase, the number of start-up studios available for interviews is limited. Consequently, the sample used in this research might not represent the diverse population of start-up studios.

The interviews introduce two forms of bias. The first one is response bias. During interviews, an effort was made to ask neutral and open-ended questions, but interviewees might still have been inclined to present information in a more positive or negative way. Secondly, there could be some researcher bias. A thematic analysis requires an interpretation of the data collected. A bias in interpretation of the researchers is thus possible.

Furthermore, findings might not apply to other continents, as all the studios interviewed were active in Europe. Finally, the interpretation of the interviews by the researchers might be influenced by subjectivity.

Chapter 3

Findings

In the following chapter, the findings from the thematic analysis of the interviews are described. The findings are categorized into four parts: key team elements, finding the needed profiles, attracting the needed profiles and promoting teamwork. Table [3.1](#) offers an overview of the central considerations for each part of the formation process.

Key team elements	Finding the needed profiles	Attracting the needed profiles	Promoting teamwork
Need for a CEO and/or CTO	Spontaneous applications	Attractiveness of the project and brand	Importance of team cohesion
Prior entrepreneurial experience	Network of core members	Equity	Focus on soft skills
Similar background industry	Network of start-up studio	Long-term incentives	Trial periods
Balance between soft and hard skills	External Engagement		Internal team
Hard skills in line with the start-up's needs			
Entrepreneurial mindset			

Table 3.1: Considerations per phase of the team formation

3.1 Key team elements

The **first step** in the team formation process of start-up studios is **defining the needed team members**. Most interviewed start-up studios stated that **every start-up starts with the recruitment of either the chief executive officer (CEO), the chief technical officer (CTO) or both**. Only one start-up studio stated that they search for four profiles at the start: a CEO, CTO, CFO (chief financial officer) and CMO (chief marketing officer). The interviews showed that start-up studios that are active in more than one industry recruit a CEO. However, in three out of four cases, **studios active in the tech industry choose to recruit a CEO and a CTO** at the start. Studios that usually do not recruit a CTO from the start state that they believe that the technical expertise can be helpful, but it's often not a necessity at the start. Furthermore, the challenge of locating these technical profiles often dissuades these start-up studios from actively seeking to recruit them.

The start-up studios defined **three crucial aspects** that they took into account when mapping out which profiles they needed: 1) background and experience, 2) needed soft and hard skills and 3) personality.

3.1.1 Background and experience

Prior **entrepreneurial experience is a required criteria for five of the seven start-up studios interviewed**. The studios **emphasized the importance of zero to one experience of the core members, such as the CEOs and CTOs discussed earlier**. **Four of the studios look for profiles that have started two or more businesses**, either self-employed or as co-founders. Additionally, **one** of the studios preferred entrepreneurs who had **failed start-ups**. The start-up studio believes that having been able to learn from the mistakes in their failed start-ups improves their ability to start the rocky process of founding a new business. Previous research on entrepreneurial learning from failure supports this hypothesis. Prior research on entrepreneurial failure has built a framework of understanding the process and impact of learning from failure. Entrepreneurs who have failed and use critical reflection on the impact factors of their failure have a learning opportunity. This learning can have a significant impact on the success of their following ventures ([Lattacher & Wdowiak, 2020](#)).

Furthermore, **two of the studios deemed prior entrepreneurial experience crucial because of the much broader and more valuable network** that these profiles possess. An empirical study has shown that founders who can rely on their strong-tie network increase the probability of the success and growth of their ventures ([Brüderl & Preisendörfer, 1998](#)).

In terms of background industry, studios that build technological start-ups emphasized that they require people who have **experience with building companies in a similar industry**. As an example, **two start-up studios that focus on building B2B technology-oriented start-ups search for members that have already built B2B tech businesses**. They also stated that **experience with the specific technology is not a necessity**, as these specific skills **can be learned in-house**. Additionally, **one venture studio** found that **recruiting members from a different industry has an advantage**, as these members can **apply trends from their previous industry** on the industry that the new start-up is active in.

3.1.2 Soft and hard skills

In relation to the skill set of potential members, the start-up studios assess the needed skills, required for the project execution. These skills vary depending on the product or service that the start-up will deliver. **In relation to soft skills, opinions were mixed**. While **several studios deemed soft skills as crucial**, others perceived it as a **non-essential bonus**. Studios that prioritize soft skills do so because they believe that these skills are **essential to surviving the turbulent environment of a start-up team**. The impact of soft skills is explored further in Section [3.4.2](#).

3.1.3 Personality

The aspect on which the venture studios placed the most emphasis is the sought-after personality traits. As stated before, start-up studios value prior entrepreneurial experience. Before, we focused on the skills that such experience brings, but a second aspect of this prior experience is the **personality and mindset** that these entrepreneurs cultivate. The entrepreneurial process brings a high work load and stress. The studios stated that a **strong entrepreneurial character is needed to endure these high levels of stress**. They believe that an entrepreneurial mindset improves the proactivity of members under such conditions. Furthermore, members with an entrepreneurial attitude can better deal with disappointments. This perseverance and passion for the long-term goals of the project, in literature often referred to as *grit*, has been shown to be important in the further success of entrepreneurs ([Salisu et al., 2020](#)). The studios' opinions were in line with this perspective. They seek people who have strong self-discipline, proactivity and an exceptional drive for the business, such that the start-up keeps moving forward during the difficult stages of the project. The start-up studios ensure that potential members carry a high level of perseverance by verifying a passionate attitude. **Not only do they take into account the passion for entrepreneurship that potential team members have, but also their passion for the project or the industry of the project itself.**

3.2 Finding the needed profiles

When the start-up studios have defined the profiles that they need, in order to launch the project, they're tasked with finding these profiles.

3.2.1 Spontaneous applications

A first distinction that can be made is whether the studios actively look for the needed profiles, or rely on unsolicited applications. Three studios mentioned using the latter technique. For one of them, this is the only method they use to hire, as they receive enough applications to be able to find the needed members. However, in the past, these studios stated that they also had to actively seek for people. Being able to rely heavily on unsolicited applications was considered a luxury and only possible for well-known studios with a good reputation. The studio that only does in-bounds also mentioned that this was done because it saves resources.

Another studio also invested in content marketing. They made podcasts, wrote articles on well-known business sites and organized webinars. They do this to attract new people and increase their publicity, so this could lead to more unsolicited applications. How start-up studios increase their attractiveness using their brand image is further explored in Section 3.3.1.

3.2.2 Network of core members

The other method for finding people is through active recruitment, which can be executed through various strategies. Four studios mentioned that they first rely on the network of the first core members to find new people. This approach was favored because the start-up team had to work closely together for a certain period and therefore the core members could estimate best who would fit in the team and who would not.

3.2.3 Network of the start-up studio

For these studios that firstly relied on the network of the core members, the next step was to use the studio network to cover the gaps left in the needed team. While these four studios preferred the network of the core team, the other interviewed studios mentioned that the first step was to look into the networks of the studio itself. Thus, all studios utilize their personal networks to identify potential new members. One studio mentioned the following: "fifty percent of people we hire, we already knew before." Additionally, another studio mentioned the advantage of the entrepreneurial network. Different start-up studios, incubators or simply entrepreneurs often know each other and keep their network in mind for entrepreneurial projects.

3.2.4 External Engagement

Three interviewees stated that they would visit business or entrepreneurial events where they could meet new people and thus expand their network. This is part of actively looking for new team members outside of their current network. This was mostly cited as the last method to find new people. However, it's worth noting that studios not only attend these events when actively hiring, but they also use it to continuously expand their network, which can then be relied on in the future, as mentioned above. One start-up studio mentioned that an alternative to visiting events was cooperating with universities. Another interviewee brought up that their last resort would be using an external recruiting agency.

3.3 Attracting the needed profiles

Once a suitable profile has been identified, the studio must now attract them to join the start-up. Sometimes, this can be a challenging task, as the risky nature of joining a start-up is not always appealing. There also exists a relationship with the Section 3.2 about finding potential members. Offering an attractive job package can improve the search for potential members, as people will be more likely to apply on their own.

3.3.1 Attractiveness of the project and brand

The first important tool to attract the needed profiles mentioned by two interviewed start-up studios is the project or idea itself. Whether the project focuses on a new fast-growing market with high potential or an idea for a smaller and more mature market makes a difference for potential members. This difference could influence some individuals' decision to take on the job. One studio added the following: "...some subjects attract some kinds of people." Therefore, some subjects attract more people and the industry could play a pivotal element in the decision-taking process of the candidate.

Research has demonstrated a positive impact of brand marketing on increasing talent acquisition efficiency. Companies that actively invest in creating and maintaining a strong brand are not only able to increase the efficiency of their hiring process, but also receive more job applications (Abdoune, M, Priyadarshin, & Vijayalakshmi, 2024). Consistent with this research, several studios stated that their brand legitimacy is a factor that increases the attractiveness of their projects. Having a successful track record of interesting projects and an attractive brand image makes attracting new members easier.

3.3.2 Financial incentives

To convince potential members to join the start-up, financial incentives seem to be the most important and most used tool, as all interviewed studios mentioned this. Financial incentives can be divided into two groups. The first one is equity and the second one are long-term incentives.

Core members should receive equity in the start-up, but how much this should amount differs from studio to studio. Most studios brought up that core members, external to the studio, should receive more than fifty percent of the shares. The reasoning behind this was clearly summarized by one studio: "they should get a good share because they are the drivers of the project." In the two studios that usually only work with a CEO and a CTO to launch the business, we saw an almost equal distribution of the equity. One studio took twenty to twenty-five percent of the shares and gave forty percent to each of the two core members, while the other studio preferred to divide the stake into three equal parts, with the CEO, CTO and the studio each receiving a third.

Not all interviewed studios liked the idea of, in addition to shares, handing out bonuses or giving long-term incentives. However, three studios used this technique to attract and motivate core members. One studio promised bonuses if they reached some predetermined key performance indicators (KPIs) before a certain date. They also clearly stated that these bonuses are fairly high to ensure motivation from these members. This studio however, didn't give out equity to the core members, but paid them a daily salary in addition to motivating them with annual and long-term bonuses. The two other studios that used long-term incentives did use equity as the first way to attract members. One offered additional options as an incentive, while the other gave the equity stake only after reaching a certain KPI.

3.4 Promoting teamwork

3.4.1 Importance of team cohesion

For a start-up to achieve its full potential, it is essential that the team works well together. A fit between the different members was often mentioned as one of the most critical parts of composing the venture team. Several studios emphasized the importance of good communication among core members, as demonstrated by quotes from two of the studios: "chemistry is super important, they need to swim together through rough waters, it's hard to start your own business, so you need the right people who communicate at the right level..." and "if the chemistry is right and people talk, they can solve the problem." Another studio, that fills in most of the positions in a new project with their own team said: "...we are such a small team and we work really hard, so it just needs to work." An example illustrating the emphasis some studios place on soft skills is that they would always prefer a candidate with moderate soft skills and hard skills over one with low soft skills and high hard skills. These quotes show that the studios attach much concern to the fit and the chemistry in the team to facilitate smoother collaboration. The following sections describe methods to ensure a good fit and communication in the new start-up.

3.4.2 Leadership soft skills

A first method brought up by some studios was extensively testing the potential candidates. Each potentially new member has a first interview with the start-up studio, but not all studios focus on the soft skills and the eventual fit between the candidate and the team in those interviews. One studio mentioned that they usually have one or more interviews that can last for multiple hours, during which they test the behavior of the candidate. With a wide range of questions, they try to test how a person would solve a certain problem or deal with peer pressure. What exactly is tested also varies according to the position for which they are hiring.

As described in Section [3.1.2](#), some studios actively focus on finding members that possess strong soft skills. For a leading position in the start-up, these studios want a clear image of the emotional intelligence of the candidate. This approach is consistent with prior research. It has been shown that a positive correlation exists between leadership soft skills and the collective learning of the new team ([Sadq, 2019](#)). Thus, testing for soft skills can be an impactful strategy in increasing the team's effectiveness and efficiency.

3.4.3 Trial periods

One interviewed studio uses trial periods for new members. After two or three weeks, they evaluate the performance of the candidate and the fit with the current culture of the team. Eventually, it is their decision whether they feel ready to work closely together in the long run.

3.4.4 Internal team

Executing most of the projects with the same internal team in different start-ups is also a technique that two interviewed studios used to assure a good team fit. These studio only hire a CEO and eventually a CTO, or other needed core members. The rest of the positions are filled by internal members of the studio. Those people are employees of the start-up studio, not the start-up, and do the same job in several start-ups at once. For example, the studio might have one CFO, who then controls and manages the financials of multiple start-ups at once as an employee of the studio.

Chapter 4

Conclusion

This study aims to uncover the way that start-up studios form teams for each of their start-ups. The findings show that the foundation of the team formation process used by these studios is the recruitment of a CEO, CTO or both. Through the network of these core members, the remaining needed members are recruited. In case these networks aren't sufficient, the studio will rely on its own networks.

Start-up studios prioritize three key properties of potential members. Entrepreneurial experience is a must. The studios want to ensure that the core members of the team, such as the CEO and CTO, can withstand the turbulent environment of a new business. Additionally, studios views on failed entrepreneurial experience are consistent with the literature in Section 1.6. They believe that finding members with prior failed ventures can be beneficial, as these members may have learned to avoid critical mistakes. Some studios also believe recruiting members from a different industry can have an advantage as these team members can apply trends from their prior industry to the current one. Moreover, the background industry of members isn't as impactful since industry-specific skills can be learned in-house. Finally, an entrepreneurial mindset with a fiery passion, described as *grit* in Section 1.7, is a crucial personality trait of potential candidates. Perseverance and passion for long-term goals prevents these members from giving up when times are tough and they have to deal with disappointments.

Studios employ a variety of strategies to identify potential members for the initial team. The first and often the preferred method isn't actively looking for those profiles, but relying on spontaneous applications. Well-known studios with a good reputation in the entrepreneurial world receive sufficient applications such that they can fill up most positions with these people. One benefit of this strategy is that it does not require as many resources as actively seeking new hires.

Some studios have a clear preference hierarchy for the methods they use when they actively recruit new employees. First, if the initial core members have already been hired, they can rely on their networks to find fitting people to collaborate on the start-up project. If these networks aren't sufficient, which is more likely if the business idea is generated internally, the studio will look into their own network. Often, start-up studios have vast entrepreneurial networks, including people from previous projects or jobs. Additionally, the findings showed that most start-up studios rely on their strong-tie networks to find members, which is consistent with the literature in Section 1.3.2.

Start-up studios attempt to broaden the candidate pools accessible to them by actively trying to expand their networks. They do this by visiting business or entrepreneurial events. If no one suitable was found or could be hired in the mentioned networks, studios might rely on a recruiting agency, or they might try to cooperate with universities and other companies.

The next phase of the team formation process is to convince suitable candidates to join the project. Several factors can increase the attraction of potential members. A first factor is the attractiveness of the projects that the studio plans on executing. Furthermore, studios with a good reputation and a successful track record can more easily convince people to join their teams, as they've proven that they can bring a start-up to its full potential. Attractiveness thus exists out of three components, the potential and risk of the project, the industry or product and lastly, the brand legitimacy.

Besides the attractiveness of the project and brand, financial incentives are essential instruments to draw in new members, since potential members tend to assume that taking on high-risk projects would provide a higher return. The most commonly used method is handing out equity and making the core team shareholders in the project. Normally, the core team receives a majority stake, while the studio becomes a minority shareholder. Long-term incentives are an alternative way to attract and motivate the team. Long-term incentives could include receiving a bonus after reaching a KPI, getting stock options or additional equity.

Good communication is essential for the efficiency and effectiveness of a small start-up team. To achieve this, new members must possess sufficient soft skills and must be able to fit in the current culture of the team. As described in the literature review under Section 1.5, soft skills of new members is an important consideration. As stated before, the studios examine the core team's networks first. This is partly done to raise the likelihood that someone who fits the team well will be found.

Studios can use multiple methods to see whether a candidate satisfies this team fit. First, the start-up studio can put a strong focus on behavior in admission interviews. With behavioral interviews, they can test for soft skills and estimate how well the candidate would fit in the team. Trial periods are a different strategy used to see how a person matches with the other core members. This is possibly the most accurate method to test the soft skills and the culture fit. However, if the outcome is negative, the studio has lost a substantial amount of time without much progression in the hiring activity.

Some studios try to eliminate personal problems at the start of a business by minimizing the number of external and new members. The internal start-up studio team then only works with a few people, such as the CEO and sometimes the CTO. In these cases, the core team of a venture builder works simultaneously on different projects. The only difference in the team formation of the projects is the CEO and possibly a CTO position. This way, the studio has more certainty that the team will fit, as overall the team stays the same. More team members are added to the team if the studio thinks the start-up is on the right path.

4.1 Future research

Our sample consisted of only seven start-up studios, which may be insufficient to draw conclusions that apply to the entire population of start-up studios in Europe. Therefore, future research should aim to draw conclusions based on a larger sample size. Our study only focused on the start-up studio population in Europe. The next logical step would be to expand to the global population of start-up studios. By interviewing more startup studios, the sample would include more types of startup studios, which mentioned in Section 1.2.5. Using this broader sample, further research could link the type of startup studio to the findings.

Additionally, the research scope could be broadened. For instance, future studies could explore the educational backgrounds of potential members and their impact on the likelihood of joining a start-up from a start-up studio. Furthermore, it could zoom in on the differences in what the studio looks for depending on the positions that they're recruiting for.

A last interesting possible research field worth mentioning is the composition of teams post-launch. While our research touched upon this subject to some extent through interview responses, there may be significant similarities with the initial team formation. Here, the focus would shift towards understanding how studios ensure team suitability for roles, maintain motivation during challenging periods and manage necessary position changes.

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